

factors (barriers) that impede members of two species from interbreeding and producing viable, fertile offspring (**Figure 24.3**). Such barriers block gene flow between the species and limit the formation of **hybrids**, offspring that result from an interspecific mating. Although a single

barrier may not prevent all gene flow, a combination of several barriers can effectively isolate a species' gene pool. Clearly, a fly cannot mate with a frog or a fern, but the reproductive barriers between more closely related species are not so obvious. As described in Figure 24.3, these barriers can be

